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The Harmonies of Hope

The Story of Chris

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THE HARMONIES OF HOPE: The Story of Chris

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*For every child who ever found God
between the block and the blessing.*

*And for every brother who stayed close
enough to hear the music.*

1

The Two-Family Flat



In the heart of Detroit, on a block where the houses leaned like tired soldiers, there was a two-family flat that held more love than its walls could contain.

The bottom floor belonged to Grandma Lois. She kept the kitchen warm year-round — not just with the stove, but with the weight of her presence. She hummed hymns while she cooked, old ones, the kind that don't have names anymore, just melodies passed down through generations of women who understood that some prayers are best sung over a pot of greens.

Chris sat at the kitchen table, eight years old, feet dangling above the linoleum. The radio was on — Motown, always Motown — and the Temptations

were singing "My Girl" while his mother ironed clothes in the next room.

"Chris, baby, go tell your brother to come eat before this food gets cold and I give it to the Lord."

He didn't move. He was listening. Not to his grandmother. Not to the radio. To something underneath both — a rhythm he couldn't name yet, a frequency that hummed between the music and the silence, between the block outside and the blessing inside.

The two-family flat sat on a street that had seen better decades. Paint peeled from porches like sunburned skin. Driveways held cars that ran on faith and starter fluid. But inside the flat, life pulsed with a warmth that no winter could freeze and no hardship could dim.

Upstairs lived Chris and his family — all seven of them packed into three bedrooms and a bathroom that required a schedule posted on the door. His mother, a woman built from equal parts prayer and iron will, ran the household with a voice that could comfort a crying baby and correct a grown man in the same breath. His father worked two jobs and still found time to sit at the head of the dinner table every evening, his hands rough but his words soft.

"How was school today?" his father would ask, looking each child in the eye, one by one, as if their

answers were the most important news in the world.

Chris was the middle child — not the oldest, who carried the weight of responsibility, and not the youngest, who carried the luxury of being babied. He was the one who watched. The one who listened. The one who noticed things that other people walked right past.

Like the way his mother's voice changed when she prayed at night — softer, more broken, like she was handing something heavy to someone she trusted completely.

Like the way the streetlights on their block flickered in a pattern that sounded, if you listened carefully, almost like a drumbeat.

Like the way music seemed to live inside the walls of their home the way electricity lived inside the wires — invisible, essential, always humming.

There were five siblings in all. The oldest, Darius, was fifteen and already talking about getting a job. He carried himself with a quiet authority that the younger ones respected, even when they didn't always obey. Next came Tamika, thirteen, who had their mother's fire and their father's stubbornness — a combination that made her both the most loved and the most argued-with person in the house. Then Chris, at eight. After him came his brother, just one

year younger, and between the two of them there was a bond that everyone in the neighborhood could see but no one could fully explain.

They weren't just brothers. They were echoes of each other.

Where Chris went, his brother followed. Where his brother laughed, Chris was already smiling. They shared a bedroom, shared clothes that almost fit them both, shared secrets whispered under blankets after the lights went out. Teachers at school often mixed up their names. Neighbors called them "the twins" even though they weren't. Their mother sometimes just pointed at both of them and said "you two" because separating them felt unnatural, like trying to pull apart a song from its melody.

The youngest was baby Keisha, still in diapers, still the center of everyone's affection, still blissfully unaware that the world outside their front door was not as warm as the one inside.



But Chris's world extended far beyond the seven people who lived upstairs.

On any given evening — and especially on weekends — the flat would fill with family in ways that defied the laws of square footage. Aunties

arrived with foil-covered pans. Uncles arrived with stories and dominoes. Cousins arrived with energy that could power a city block.

"Y'all go in the back," the adults would say, waving the children toward the bedrooms like a crossing guard directing traffic. And the children obeyed — not because they wanted to, but because respect was not optional in a Black household in Detroit in the 1990s. Respect was the air you breathed. You said "yes ma'am" and "no sir" and you did not talk back and you absolutely, under no circumstances, interrupted grown folks when they were talking.

But what happened in the back rooms was its own kind of magic.

The cousins would pile into the bedrooms — eight, ten, sometimes twelve deep — and the games would begin. Monopoly marathons that lasted three hours and ended in accusations of cheating. Wrestling matches on the floor until someone hit the wall too hard and an uncle's voice boomed from the living room: "Y'all better not break nothing in there!"

Sometimes they played hide-and-seek in a space too small to hide in, which made it funnier. Sometimes they told ghost stories under a blanket tent while someone held a flashlight under their

chin. Sometimes they just lay on the floor and talked — about school, about crushes, about what they wanted to be when they grew up.

"I'm gonna be a fireman," one cousin would say.

"I'm gonna play in the NBA," said another.

"I'm gonna be rich," said a third, with the confidence of someone who had never seen a bank statement.

Chris didn't always answer. He'd lie on his back, staring at the ceiling, listening to the muffled sounds of the adults in the other room — the laughter, the music, the clink of glasses, the rhythm of conversation that rose and fell like waves. And he'd think: *This is what home sounds like.*

One by one, the cousins would fall asleep wherever they landed. On beds, on floors, on piles of coats that had been tossed into corners. The adults would peek in, shake their heads with a smile, and close the door softly.

Those nights bonded the cousins in ways that regular family ties couldn't explain. They became more than relatives. They became a tribe. They were connected by blood, yes, but also by the shared memory of being small together, of being safe together, of falling asleep to the sound of love in the next room.



2

The Brothers



Among all his siblings, Chris shared something with his brother that went deeper than proximity. It was deeper than shared meals and shared bedtimes and shared punishment when one of them broke something and neither would confess. What they shared was a frequency — a way of being in the world that vibrated at the same pitch.

His brother was only a year younger, but people often thought they were the same age. They were the same height, had the same walk, laughed at the same things. When one of them started a sentence, the other could finish it. When one got hurt, the other flinched.

"You two are like one person in two bodies," their aunt once said, shaking her head.

Their mother said it differently: "God made y'all close for a reason. Don't ever let the world pull you apart."

Every morning, they walked to school together. Not side by side in a formal way, but in the loose, gravitational orbit that brothers have — one slightly ahead, then the other, then shoulder to shoulder, then one lagging behind to pick up a rock or kick a can. They didn't always talk. They didn't need to. The silence between them was its own kind of conversation.

At school, they were known. Not for being troublemakers — though they had their moments — but for being inseparable. If a teacher sent one to the office, the other would mysteriously appear five minutes later with some excuse about needing to use the bathroom. If one got into an argument on the playground, the other materialized at his side before the first fist was raised.

People joked about it. "If you got a problem with one of them, you got a problem with both of them."

It was funny because it was true.

But the real bond — the one that would shape both of their lives — was music.

It started at home. Their older siblings had instruments. Darius played keyboard with the kind of casual skill that suggested he could be great if he

ever decided to take it seriously. Tamika had a flute she practiced in the bathroom because the acoustics were better, she claimed, though everyone suspected she just wanted privacy.

Chris and his brother would sit in the hallway and listen. They'd press their ears against doors. They'd tap rhythms on their legs, on tables, on walls, on anything that vibrated. Their mother found them once beating drumsticks on upturned pots in the kitchen, and instead of scolding them, she stood in the doorway and smiled.

"Lord," she said quietly. "These boys got music in their blood."

She was right. But she didn't know yet how deep it ran.



When Chris was in fourth grade, the school introduced concert band. A man in a brown suit came to the auditorium and laid out instruments on a long table like a buffet of possibility. Trumpets gleamed under the fluorescent lights. Clarinets lay in velvet cases like sleeping animals. A tuba sat in the corner like a brass throne.

Chris walked along the table slowly, his eyes wide, his fingers hovering over each instrument but

not quite touching. He stopped in front of the trombone.

It was long and golden and awkward and beautiful. It had a slide instead of keys, which meant you had to feel the notes instead of just pressing buttons. It required breath and precision and something that Chris would later learn to call *soul*.

He picked it up. It was heavier than he expected.

"That one's hard," the band teacher said, watching him. "Most kids don't stick with it."

Chris looked at him. "I will."

His brother, standing two feet behind him — always two feet behind him — reached for the drums. Not the snare. Not the bass. The full kit. He sat down behind it with the kind of natural ease that made the band teacher raise an eyebrow.

"You've played before?" the teacher asked.

His brother shrugged. "I've been playing my whole life. Just not on these."

From that day forward, music became the third brother. It walked with them to school. It sat between them at lunch. It filled their bedroom at night when they practiced — Chris with his trombone propped on a pillow to muffle the sound, his brother tapping rhythms on his mattress with pencils.

Together they spent countless hours practicing, learning new songs, encouraging one another to improve. Chris would play a phrase, and his brother would find the beat underneath it. His brother would lay down a rhythm, and Chris would build a melody on top. They didn't plan it. They didn't rehearse it. It just happened — the way harmony happens when two voices are tuned to the same key.

The band room at school became their sanctuary. It was the one place where the noise of the world made sense. Where the chaos of the neighborhood reorganized itself into time signatures and chord progressions. Where a boy from a two-family flat in Detroit could close his eyes, press cold brass to his lips, and feel something larger than himself move through the music.

His band teacher, Mr. Coleman, noticed early.

"Chris," he said one afternoon after rehearsal, "you've got something. I don't know what to call it yet. But don't let go of it."

Chris nodded. He didn't know what to call it either. But he felt it — a pull, a purpose, a sound that seemed to come from somewhere deeper than his lungs.

Every note he played carried him further away from the fears and struggles surrounding his

neighborhood and closer to the hope of something greater.



3

Mom and Pop



Chris's parents were pillars of strength and unwavering faith. Not the kind of faith that shows up on Sunday morning and disappears by Monday afternoon — but the kind that gets woven into the fabric of daily life until you can't tell where the person ends and the prayer begins.

His mother prayed like she cooked — with her whole body, with no shortcuts, with the understanding that what she was making would feed people long after she was done. She prayed in the morning before anyone woke up. She prayed at night after everyone went to sleep. She prayed in the car, at the store, at the kitchen sink with her hands in dishwater.

"Lord, cover my children," she'd whisper, so softly that you'd miss it if you weren't paying

attention. But Chris was always paying attention.

His father showed his faith differently. He didn't pray out loud as often, but his life was a prayer — steady, consistent, showing up when it was hard, staying when it would've been easier to leave. He worked the early shift at the plant and a late shift at the warehouse, and still made it home in time to sit at the dinner table with his family.

Every evening, no matter how tired he was, no matter how long the day had been, the family gathered. The table was small and the food was simple, but the ritual was sacred.

"How was school today?" his father would ask.

And each child would answer, knowing that their father wasn't just asking — he was listening. Really listening. The way you listen when someone's words are the most important sound in the room.

After dinner, before the dishes were done, came the prayer.

"Let's bow our heads," his father would say, and the entire household would go quiet — even baby Keisha, as if she understood that this moment mattered.

The prayers weren't fancy. They weren't long. But they were real.

"Lord, thank you for this table. Thank you for these children. Keep them safe. Keep them humble.

Keep them Yours."

And then came the words that Chris would carry with him for the rest of his life — the words his parents repeated so often they became tattooed on his soul:

"Stay active, pray up, and keep the faith; otherwise, the streets will swallow you whole."

Chris didn't fully understand those words when he was eight. He heard them the way children hear all warnings — as background noise, as something adults say because adults say things like that. But the words planted themselves like seeds. They buried deep. And they would bloom later, at exactly the moment he needed them most.



4

The Move



Then life changed in a way Chris never expected.

It started with a conversation he wasn't supposed to hear. Late one night, lying in bed with his brother asleep beside him, Chris heard his parents talking in the kitchen. Their voices were low, but the walls in the flat were thin, and Chris had learned to listen through walls the way other kids learned to read books.

"We got the call," his mother said. "We can move."

"When?" his father asked.

"Next month. The house on Chestnut. Three bedrooms. A yard. Good schools."

There was a silence. Then his father's voice, thick with something Chris couldn't identify at the time but would later recognize as relief:

"Thank God."

The next few weeks were a blur of boxes and tape and arguments about what to keep and what to leave behind. Tamika cried because she didn't want to leave her best friend. Darius pretended he didn't care but spent an entire afternoon sitting on the porch looking at the street like he was memorizing it. Baby Keisha didn't understand anything, which was probably a mercy.

Chris felt something he couldn't name. Not sadness, exactly. Not excitement, exactly. Something in between. Something like standing at the edge of a diving board — wanting to jump but afraid of the water below.

Detroit's streets, familiar faces, and memories had shaped him. The corner store where Mr. Leroy gave him a free Now and Later every Friday. The fire hydrant that the neighborhood kids opened every summer, turning the street into a water park. The cracked sidewalk where he'd chalked his name in letters so big you could see them from the end of the block.

He was leaving all of it.

But the day they arrived at their new home felt almost unreal.

The neighborhood was different in a way that Chris felt in his chest before he understood it in his

mind. The houses stood straight. The lawns were green and cut. There were trees — not the scraggly, urban trees that grew through cracks in the concrete, but real trees with thick trunks and branches that reached toward the sky like arms raised in worship.

Children rode bikes on sidewalks that were smooth and uncracked. Families sat on porches and waved at the moving truck as it passed. A man walking his dog nodded and said, "Welcome to the neighborhood."

Chris's brother appeared at his side — always at his side — and they stood in the driveway of their new home, looking up at it like it was a castle.

"It's so big," his brother said.

It wasn't. Not really. But compared to the two-family flat, it was a mansion. Three bedrooms. A real kitchen. A backyard with a fence and a patch of grass that their mother would eventually fill with tomatoes and roses and prayers.

"Boys," their father said, carrying a box past them. "Welcome home."

Home. The word landed differently here. In the old neighborhood, home was a place you returned to. A shelter. A base. Here, it felt like something you could grow into. Something that had room for the people they hadn't yet become.

That first night, Chris and his brother lay in their new room — their own room, for the first time in their lives — and stared at the ceiling.

"You think we'll like it here?" his brother asked.

Chris thought about it. "I think we already do."

Outside, the streetlights glowed steady and warm. No flickering. No buzzing. Just light.

And somewhere in the distance, Chris could swear he heard music.



5

The Church



Not long after the move, a longtime family friend affectionately known as "Auntie" — though she wasn't related by blood, just by love — invited the family to visit a nearby church.

"Y'all need a church home," she said, in the way that Black women say things that are equal parts invitation and commandment. "Come Sunday. Wear something nice. And bring those babies."

Chris's mother didn't need convincing. She'd been looking for a church since the day they moved. The old church back in the flat's neighborhood had been their anchor, and leaving it had left a gap that nothing else had filled.

But Chris hesitated. Not because he didn't want to go — he'd grown up in church the way fish grow up in water. It was just what you did. But this was a

new church, with new people and new pews and new rules he didn't know yet. What if they sang different songs? What if the pastor preached different? What if the kids there didn't like him?

Sunday morning came, and his mother answered all his objections by handing him a pressed shirt and saying, "Put that on and get in the car."

The church was a brick building on a corner lot, modest but well-kept, with a wooden cross above the door and a sign that read: *All Are Welcome. Come As You Are*. People were gathered outside — men in suits, women in hats, children in clothes they clearly didn't want to be wearing. But everyone was smiling. Everyone.

The moment Chris stepped inside the sanctuary, something shifted.

The air was different. Warmer. Not from the heating — from the people. They turned and looked at the family the way people look at someone they've been expecting. Hands reached out. Smiles widened. Voices called out:

"Welcome!"

"Come on in, family!"

"Is this Auntie's people? Come sit up front!"

And then the music started.

A Hammond organ rumbled from somewhere behind the pulpit, low and warm, like thunder you

could feel in your chest. A drummer — a real drummer, not the kind who just keeps time but the kind who speaks through the skins — laid down a groove that made the pews vibrate. And the choir stood up.

They didn't just sing. They *released* something. The sound poured out like water breaking through a dam — rich, full, layered, alive. Altos and sopranos and tenors braided together in a harmony that didn't just fill the room. It filled Chris.

He sat in the pew, eight years old, hands gripping the edge of the seat, and felt tears on his cheeks that he didn't remember crying.

His brother, sitting next to him, elbowed him gently. "You okay?"

Chris nodded. But he wasn't okay. He was something bigger than okay. He was home.

Before long, the church became a second home for Chris and his family. The sermons inspired them — not the shouting, fire-and-brimstone kind, but the quiet, steady, look-you-in-the-eye kind that reminded Chris of his father. The pastor had a way of making the Bible feel like it was written yesterday, for the people in this room, about the problems on this block.

"Faith the size of a mustard seed," the pastor said one Sunday, holding up his thumb and forefinger an

inch apart. "That's all it takes. Not a mountain of faith. Not a river. Just a seed. Just enough to say, 'God, I don't understand, but I trust You anyway.'"

Chris wrote those words in the margin of his bulletin. He'd keep that bulletin for years.

Through youth activities, fellowship gatherings, and Sunday potlucks that rivaled Grandma Lois's cooking, Chris found himself surrounded by people who genuinely cared about him. Not because they had to. Not because they were related. But because that's what the church was — a family you chose, and that chose you back.



6

The Water



The decision came on a regular Wednesday evening.

Chris was sitting in youth Bible study when the youth pastor, Brother James, asked a question that sounded simple but wasn't:

"Who are you living for?"

The room got quiet. A few kids shifted in their chairs. One girl said, "God." Another boy said, "My family." Someone in the back muttered, "Myself," which got a laugh, but Brother James didn't smile.

"Honest answer," he said. "Most of us are living for whatever's loudest. Whatever's closest. Whatever feels good right now. But God isn't loud. God isn't always close. And God doesn't always feel good. He feels *right*. And there's a difference."

Chris didn't answer out loud. But something in his chest — the same thing that responded to music, the same thing that hummed between the block and the blessing — stirred.

That night, he told his mother he wanted to be baptized.

She didn't cry. Not then. She just put her hand on his cheek and said, "Baby, I've been praying for this day since before you were born."

His brother said he wanted to be baptized too. And then Tamika. And then Darius, who acted like it was no big deal even though everyone could see his hands shaking.

The baptism was on a Sunday. The church was full. Family came from the old neighborhood — aunties and uncles and cousins who packed the pews the way they used to pack the flat. Grandma Lois sat in the front row, hands folded, eyes closed, lips moving in a prayer that no one could hear but everyone could feel.

One by one, the siblings walked into the water.

When it was Chris's turn, he stood at the edge of the baptismal pool and looked out at the congregation. He saw his mother, tears streaming. His father, jaw tight, eyes shining. His brother, already baptized, dripping wet, grinning at him from the side.

The pastor placed a hand on his back. "Do you accept Jesus Christ as your Lord and Savior?"

"Yes."

"Then I baptize you in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit."

The water closed over his head. For one second — maybe less — the world went silent. No music. No voices. No noise from the block or the blessing. Just stillness. Just peace.

And then he rose.

The congregation erupted. Hands clapped. Voices shouted. The organ played. And Chris stood in the water, water running down his face, and felt something he'd never felt before — not happiness, exactly, but something deeper. Something that settled into his bones like a promise.

I am not the same person I was thirty seconds ago.

It was more than a ceremony. It was a public declaration of faith and a commitment to continue walking with God no matter what challenges life might bring.

After the baptism, his mother pulled all five siblings into a hug so tight that baby Keisha squealed. His father stood behind them, one hand on each of his sons' shoulders, and said nothing. He didn't need to. His eyes said everything.



7

The Choir



After being baptized, Chris and his siblings became even more involved in the church. They volunteered for everything — setting up chairs, passing out bulletins, helping in the kitchen. But it was the junior choir that captured their hearts.

Week after week, they faithfully attended rehearsals and sang during Sunday services. The experience brought the siblings even closer, strengthening both their love for music and their faith in God.

The junior choir wasn't large — maybe fifteen kids on a good Sunday — but what they lacked in numbers they made up for in heart. They sang traditional hymns with the solemnity of a cathedral choir and gospel songs with the energy of a concert.

They swayed and clapped and lifted their hands, and the adults in the congregation smiled and cried and said "Sing, children! Sing!"

Chris loved every second of it. He loved the way voices sounded when they blended together — not like separate people singing the same song, but like one voice made of many. He loved the way the music built, layer upon layer, until it filled the sanctuary like light fills a room at sunrise. He loved the way singing made him feel connected — to the other kids, to the congregation, to something he was beginning to understand was bigger than all of them.

As time passed, the church youth grew closer to Chris's family. What began as simple friendships soon became something much deeper. Chris's parents welcomed the young people from church with the same warmth they showed their own children — meals at the table, wisdom at the door, love without conditions.

The youth admired the warmth and guidance they received from Chris's mother and father. Before long, many of them affectionately began calling them "Mom" and "Pop."

The church no longer felt like just a place of worship. It felt like family.



8

Now Direct



One of the youth overseers began noticing something special about Chris. Her name was Sister Denise, and she had been working with the junior choir for twelve years. She'd seen hundreds of young people come through the doors — some stayed, some drifted, some burned bright and faded. But Chris was different.

She saw not only his passion for music but also the leadership qualities quietly growing inside him. The way he helped younger kids learn their parts. The way he stood a little taller when the choir was singing well. The way he listened — truly listened — not just to the notes, but to the spaces between them.

She watched him for weeks. She prayed about it. And then she made her move.

One evening during junior choir rehearsal, while the choir was warming up and the chatter filled the room with the comfortable noise of young people being young, Sister Denise walked over to Chris.

She didn't say anything at first. She just smiled — that warm, knowing smile that church mothers have perfected over centuries — and gently grabbed him by the hand.

Chris looked up at her, confused. "Ma'am?"

She didn't answer. She led him from his spot in the second row — where he always stood, between two altos, slightly behind his brother — to the front of the choir stand.

The room became quiet. Not all at once, but in a wave, like someone had slowly turned down the volume. Kids stopped talking. Music folders lowered. All eyes turned to Chris, who stood at the front of the choir with his heart hammering so loud he was sure everyone could hear it.

Sister Denise stood beside him for a moment. She placed a hand on his shoulder.

Then she smiled and said four words that would change the trajectory of his life:

"Now direct the choir."

Chris froze.

He looked at Sister Denise. She nodded.

He looked at the choir. Fifteen faces stared back at him — some curious, some amused, some skeptical. His sister Tamika raised an eyebrow that said *you better not mess this up*.

He looked at his brother, standing behind the drum kit, sticks resting on the snare, a grin spreading across his face that said *I got you*.

Chris turned back to the choir. He felt his hands trembling. He felt his breath catch. He felt every doubt he'd ever had about himself rush to the surface like air bubbles in water.

I'm not a director. I'm just a kid. I sing in the second row. I play trombone. I'm nobody special.

But then — underneath the doubt, underneath the fear — he heard it. That frequency. That hum. The sound that lived between the block and the blessing, between the music and the silence, between who he was and who he was becoming.

Slowly, he lifted his arms.

At first, his movements were timid and unsure. His hands shook. His timing was off. He gave a downbeat that came half a second too late, and the choir stumbled into the first measure like runners tripping over a starting line.

But his brother caught it. From behind the drums, his brother adjusted — slowed the tempo, steadied the groove, gave Chris a foundation to

stand on. It was instinct. It was love. It was everything their bond had been building toward since those nights in the two-family flat, tapping rhythms on upturned pots.

Chris took a breath. He reset. He gave the downbeat again.

This time, the choir responded. The sopranos came in clean. The altos held their line. The tenors found their note. And the sound — that glorious, unified, heaven-reaching sound — rose up around Chris like water, like light, like grace.

He started guiding the rhythm with growing confidence, moving his hands in time with the music. The choir followed his lead beautifully, their voices blending together as Chris directed them with a joy he had never experienced before — a joy that was different from singing, different from playing trombone, different from anything he'd known.

This was what he was made for.

He could feel it in his arms, in his chest, in the tears that gathered in his eyes but didn't fall. He was conducting, yes — but he was also being conducted. Something larger was moving through him, using his hands to shape the sound, using his heart to hold the beat.

Standing nearby behind the drums was his brother, faithfully playing alongside him. Their eyes met once during the song, and in that look was everything — every walk to school, every shared bedroom, every night falling asleep to the sound of family in the next room. They didn't need words. They never had.

Sister Denise stood at the side of the room, arms crossed, tears running down her face, smiling the smile of someone who had just watched a seed become a tree.

When the song ended, the room was silent for a beat. Then two. Then three.

And then it erupted.

Clapping. Cheering. Feet stomping. Tamika shouting from the back row, "That's my BROTHER!" His brother hitting a celebratory drum fill that rattled the windows. Sister Denise walking over to him, taking his face in both her hands, and saying:

"I knew it. I knew it since the first day you walked in here. God put music in you, boy. Now you know why."



9

The Harmony Unfolds



At such a young age, Chris had already experienced tremendous change.

He had moved into a new home. Started at a new school. Joined a new church. Publicly given his life to God through baptism. Formed new friendships that felt like family. Joined the junior choir alongside his siblings. And now — standing at the front of the choir stand each Sunday, arms raised, heart full — he had become the director of the junior choir.

For Chris, life finally seemed full of hope and promise.

The lessons of faith, family, music, and community were shaping him into someone stronger than he ever imagined he could be. Each Sunday brought new songs, new challenges, new

moments where the music carried him somewhere he couldn't go alone. Each rehearsal was a prayer. Each performance was a testimony.

His trombone sat in the corner of his bedroom, still loved, still played on quiet evenings when the house was still. But his true instrument now was the choir itself — fifteen voices that he was learning to shape, to blend, to lift.

His brother stayed behind the drums. Every Sunday. Every rehearsal. Every performance. The two of them moved in the kind of harmony that can't be taught — the kind that comes from growing up in the same flat, hearing the same prayers, dreaming the same dreams.

As summer slowly faded and middle school approached, Chris felt both excitement and nervousness about the next chapter of his life. He knew challenges would come. He'd heard the whispers. Seen the older boys on corners. Watched families in the old neighborhood unravel like thread pulled from a sweater.

He knew the streets were patient. They would wait.

But he also knew something else — something his parents had planted in him like a seed, something the church had watered, something the music had brought to bloom:

He was not alone.

He had his family — five siblings, two parents, and a web of aunts, uncles, and cousins who had shown him that love doesn't need a mansion. It just needs a room.

He had his church — a building made of brick and wood that somehow contained more warmth than any palace. A choir stand that felt like a throne. A community that called his parents "Mom" and "Pop" and meant it.

He had his faith — small, maybe. Mustard-seed small. But growing. Always growing. Fed by every prayer, every hymn, every quiet moment when he felt God's presence the way he felt music — not as something he could see, but as something he could not deny.

And he had music — the golden thread that ran through everything, connecting the flat to the church, the trombone to the choir, the block to the blessing. Music was his language. His inheritance. His calling.

With his trombone in one hand and faith in his heart, Chris stepped forward into the future, determined to face whatever came next.

The harmony of his life was still unfolding. New movements waited. New melodies hid around corners he couldn't yet see. There would be

dissonance — he knew that. Notes that clashed. Rhythms that broke. Moments when the music would stop entirely and the silence would feel unbearable.

But he also knew, with the certainty of someone who has stood in the water and risen again, that the song never truly ends.

It just changes key.



End of Volume One

*The Harmonies of Hope: Vol. II — The Choir Stand
Coming 2026*



About the Author

C.D. Howell was born and raised in Detroit, Michigan. The son of working-class parents who believed in God, music, and the power of family, he grew up in a two-family flat on Detroit's east side before moving to a new neighborhood that changed the trajectory of his life. A lifelong musician, choir director, and man of faith, C.D. writes stories that honor where he came from while pointing toward where grace can take you.

The Harmonies of Hope is his debut novel.

He currently resides in North Carolina with his family.

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